



THE WAR IN EUROPE

THE ALLIED BATTLE TO TURN BACK THE TIDE OF NAZI CONTROL

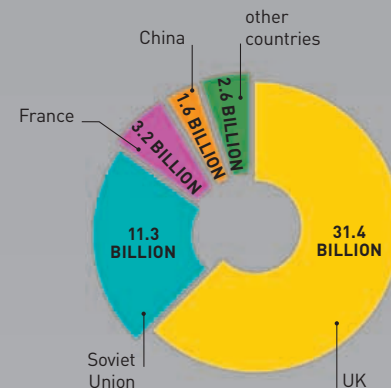
The German invasion of Poland in September 1939 provoked Britain and France to declare war on Germany. At first the Germans won an astonishing series of victories, but from 1942 onward they were overwhelmed by the combined strength of the US, the Soviet Union, and Britain.

After the rapid defeat of Poland in April 1940, the Germans invaded Denmark and Norway. Their devastating campaign swiftly overran the Netherlands, Belgium, and France. British Forces escaped from Europe through an evacuation from Dunkirk in France. The Luftwaffe failed to overcome the RAF in the Battle of Britain in summer 1940, but British cities were subjected to night bombing raids during the Blitz.

The entry of Italy into the war in June 1940 spread the fighting to the Mediterranean and North Africa. Needing to rescue Italian forces from

defeat, the German army swept south to Crete and intervened in North Africa. Hitler's invasion of the Soviet Union in June 1941 brought German forces to the gates of Moscow and Leningrad. But the German drive eastward came to a catastrophic end at Stalingrad in late 1942.

Defeated in North Africa, the Germans then faced an Allied invasion of Italy. In summer 1944, the Allies landed in Normandy and broke out to liberate France and Belgium. A final German counterattack in the Ardennes was repulsed, and Germany was finally invaded from east and west.



US lend-lease

The US provided its Allies with vast quantities of war equipment and supplies, under the lend-lease program. Britain and the Soviet Union were the major beneficiaries.

EUROPE IN 1942 By 1942 Nazi Germany dominated mainland Europe. Its allies and satellites included Italy, Hungary, Bulgaria, Slovakia, Croatia, and Vichy France. Greater Germany expanded before and during the war to include Austria, French Alsace-Lorraine, and much of Poland (which ceased to exist as a state in October 1939). Although the Nazis found some willing collaborators, their ambition to found a "New Order" in Europe eventually came to nothing.